



Dawn, the computer-generated fairy, showcases what nVidia's graphics engines can create—in real-time

// It's funny, because you make a lot of Indian movies, more than Hollywood, with Indian characters and content. and yet, in the games industry, you only play Westerners //



Gollum represents a leap forward in animation

franchise) for a while, which then moved on to another company. This game's been through five or six companies, so it looks like if a company touches it, it's in trouble. It contains awesome work, my favourite. But since I don't have the rights to show you that—the project's gone to someone else—you'll never see it!

■ **Is this the case for most artists—their best work is not always published?**

No, often I think they're lucky. There's an artist we've got in Sydney. He's working on a company project that hasn't been unveiled yet. But he works in his spare time on his folio, and some of the stuff in there far surpasses the work actually in the game. But this isn't always the case. Take Gollum for example. Oh boy, are they showing their best work! If you've got better work than Gollum, I'm just gonna kill myself! (laughs)

■ **What is it like behind the scenes? Where does the artist's work begin?**

The first interaction is with the game designer. Here you create a concept, and the feedback is given immediately. You can smoothen the whole process, which makes for a much better product. So the artist's job really starts by opening up a good conduit to the designer.

■ **How have the tools you used evolved over the years?**

The best thing about new tools is not the features, but the ease. Ever since there's been competition between 3D software packages, you've seen better interfaces, and I can only hope this just keeps going. Essentially, I'd like to work at the speed of thought—you think of something and do it. Right now, you have to sit and work out mechanically what you have to do. If you want to make a nose, make a nose; and we're seeing that with interfaces now. They've evolved hugely. What I would love to see in the next generation of 3D tools is for them go over the old features, and make them smooth, silky and easy to use.

■ **What do you think game artists need to learn to make it big?**

The keyword is art. As artists, you need to be able to "look" correctly, and see. Life Study drawing classes are vital, because they teach you how to look at the world around you in terms of shape,

form, light, shadow, mass, muscle, structure, anatomy, proportion... I could go on and on. The actual fundamentals of the art—that's where you should begin. In the Indian market, because they don't have a lot of experience in engines and tools, the way they can get over that is by studying the art, the actual principles behind it all. Check out books like *Illusion of Life*, which are the Walt Disney books, and spend time on the Net and really look at what people are doing out there.

■ **Internationally, how many Indian artists or animators have you come across who're in the same field as yours?**

I have one animator who's Indian. He's actually a naturalised Australian, but his parents are Indian. I haven't actually counted that many in Australia.

■ **How difficult will it be for Indian talent to make it big internationally?**

Well, the trick is to make games that are interesting and fun to play, games that are polished and have something that's just slightly different about them. We're very sick of playing drab, grey Gothic horror games, World War II games, and so on. Seeing new genres is hard today, but seeing new times and places and fantasies and mythologies—Indian mythology, for example—would evoke

great interest. The West has embraced Japanese and Korean games, so it's entirely possible that Indian games go the same way.

■ **It's interesting you said that, because Paradox Entertainment, which is developing *BattleDust: The Championship*, says that it included international characters to appeal to the foreign market. Are you saying that**



The Alien is an icon of the horror sci-fi genre



Middle Earth Online is a highly anticipated MMORPG